

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Navajo Code Talker Thomas H. Begay, who is at least 100, sits at a war memorial on June 9 in Albuquerque, New Mexico.

Senate nears vote on deal

Speaker tells House members to return to DC for session to end government shutdown

By Mary Clare Jalonick
and Lisa Mascaro
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The Senate was drawing closer to a vote on legislation to end the shutdown on Monday after a small group of Senate Democrats broke a 40-day stalemate late Sunday evening and voted with Republicans to move forward with reopening the government.

It is unclear when the Senate will hold final votes on the bill, but Senate Majority Leader John Thune said he hopes passage will take “hours not days.”

“The American people have suffered for long enough. Let’s not pointlessly drag this bill out,” he said as the Senate opened on Monday morning.

The legislation would still need to clear the House before the government could reopen. Speaker Mike Johnson urged lawmakers to start returning to Washington “right now” given travel delays, but he said he would issue an official notice for the House’s return once the Senate passes the legislation.

“We have to do this as quickly as possible,” Johnson said at a news conference. He has kept the House out of session since mid-September, when it passed a bill to continue government funding.

After weeks of negotiations, the moderate Senate Democrats agreed to reopen the government without a guaranteed extension of health care subsidies, angering many in their caucus who have demanded that Republicans negotiate with them on the Affordable Care Act tax credits that expire Jan. 1. Senate Majority Leader John Thune, R-S.D., promised a mid-December vote on the subsidies.

Sunday’s final vote was 60-40. Senate Democratic leader Chuck Schumer of New York voted against moving ahead with the package, along with all but eight of his Democratic colleagues.

“We will not give up the fight,” Schumer said, adding that Democrats have now “sounded the alarm” on health care.

Still, an end to the shutdown could be days away if any senators object and drag out the process. Thune was working out concerns within his Republican conference about individual provisions in the underlying spending bills.

One of those Republicans, Kentucky Sen. Rand Paul, had threatened to object to a provision

Turn to Vote, Page 11

In Arizona, a fading Route 66 motel hides a story of the Navajo Code Talkers

By Jonathan Bullington
Chicago Tribune

FLAGSTAFF, Ariz. — The El Pueblo Motor Inn, or what’s left of it anyway, sits vacant behind a chain-link fence along Route 66, its stucco walls clad in weathered sheets of construction tarp.

At first glance, the nearly 90-year-old motel appears to be another crumbling relic from the famed highway’s early years as a bustling thoroughfare for hundreds of thousands of Americans traveling between Los Angeles and Chicago.

But this isn’t just a fading Route 66 roadside attraction.

Six years after El Pueblo motel opened its doors, with the country plunged into World War II following the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor, the motel’s proprietor, Philip Johnston, devised a plan to enlist Navajo men into the U.S. Marines Corps. Their mission: create a secret code based on Diné Bizaad, the unwritten Navajo language, that could not be broken.

It’s believed that Johnston’s motel served as a recruitment outpost and way station for some new recruits en route to the Southern California base where they would train to become Navajo Code Talkers.

From an initial group of 29, more than 400 Navajo men would eventually become Code Talkers, rapidly transmitting hundreds of thousands of encrypted messages through some of the fiercest battles in the Pacific theater — messages that opposing forces never deciphered.

“Without these brave men and their knowledge of their language, the war in the Pacific would have been prolonged with great human loss,” then-U.S. Sen. Ben Nighthorse Campbell, R-CO, said during a 2001 congressional Gold Medal ceremony for the first 29 Code Talkers. “And



The vacant El Pueblo Motor Inn sits along Route 66 on June 6 in Flagstaff, Arizona.
E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

“Without these brave men and their knowledge of their language, the war in the Pacific would have been prolonged with great human loss.”

—former U.S. Sen. Ben Nighthorse Campbell, speaking at a 2001 congressional ceremony

maybe it would not have turned out the way it did.”

Of the 400 or so Code Talkers, only two are alive today: Peter MacDonald and Thomas H. Begay. Both men sat down with the Chicago Tribune this summer to talk about their experiences during the war and their hopes for the El Pueblo Motor Inn.

This is the story of the last two Code Talkers and the mastermind behind the

top secret program whose Route 66 motel faces an uncertain future.

Two teens join the Marines

World War II came to Thomas Begay on a gravel football field near the Arizona-New Mexico border. There, a boarding school classmate heard on the radio that Japanese planes had bombarded

Turn to Navajo, Page 4

INSIDE

\$17M settlement OK'd in police misconduct case

Chicago aldermen advanced another police misconduct settlement, this one tied to the alleged wrongful conviction of a man who spent 27 years in custody. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Trump pardons Giuliani, other accused allies

In addition to Rudy Giuliani, the president pardoned his onetime chief of staff Mark Meadows and others accused of backing efforts to overturn the 2020 election. **Nation & World**

Durbin defends GOP-backed shutdown vote



Sen. Dick Durbin speaks during the Illinois Democratic County Chairs' Association brunch on Aug. 13 in Springfield. “Many of my friends are unhappy,” he said Monday in reference to his vote on the Senate floor.
DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin, one of eight members of the chamber to cross party lines and endorse a GOP plan to end the nation’s longest government shutdown, defended his vote on the Senate floor Monday amid intense party criticism of the deal.

“Many of my friends are unhappy. They think we should have kept our government closed indefinitely to protest the policies of the Trump administration,” Durbin said, as he continued to blame the shutdown on President Donald Trump and allied Republicans.

“I share their opinions of this administration, but cannot accept a strategy which wages political

battle at the expense of my neighbors’ paycheck or the food for his children,” said Durbin, Illinois’ senior senator and the chamber’s No. 2 ranking Democrat.

The vote by Durbin, who will retire at the end of his fifth term in January 2027, reflects the veteran lawmaker’s deeply rooted institutional beliefs. He said during the vote Sunday night that he met with Senate Republican Leader John Thune, of South Dakota, and told “him that I was counting on him to keep his word on this agreement. He assured me he would.”

Under the proposed Senate agreement, the government would reopen until Jan. 30, and measures to fully fund the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program,

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TODAY’S
WEATHER



High 41 Low 37

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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